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In order to reduce the number of items damaged while in transit to customers, packaging consultants recommended the TrueSave mail-order company increase the amount of packing material so as to fill any empty spaces in its cartons. Accordingly, TrueSave officials instructed the company's packers to use more packing material than before, and the packers zealously acted on these instructions and used as much as they could. Nevertheless, customer reports of damaged items rose somewhat.

Which of the following, if true, most helps to explain why acting on the consultants' recommendation failed to achieve its goal?

A. The change in packing policy led to an increase in expenditure on packing material and labor.

B. When packing material is compressed too densely, it loses some of its capacity to absorb shock.

C. The amount of packing material used in a carton does not significantly influence the ease with which a customer can unpack the package.

D. Most of the goods TrueSave ships are electronic products that are highly vulnerable to being damaged in transit.

E. TrueSave has lost some of its regular customers as a result of the high number of damaged items they received.

Arguement Construction

Situation TrueSave company followed consultants' recommendations to decrease damage to its shipments by increasing the amount of packing material. Workers stuffed in as much material as they could, but the number of items damaged in shipping increased rather than decreased.

Reasoning *What would cause a correlation between increased packing materials and increased rates of damaged items?* Using more packing material might be ineffective at preventing damage to shipped items if such tightly packed materials had unforeseen effects. Identifying such an effect could help explain why the consultants' recommendation to use more materials backfired.

A. Increased expenditure on packing materials and labor would not explain why more items were damaged during shipping after the recommendations were put into practice.

B. **Correct.** If densely compressed packing material is less effective at absorbing shock, then excessive use of packing materials could backfire by transmitting more shock, not less, to packed items. If TrueSave's workers are stuffing in packing materials too vigorously, that would help explain why the recommendation to use more materials has led to somewhat increased rates of damaged shipments.

C. The ease of unpacking TrueSave's shipments is not relevant to the question of why items are damaged during shipping.

D. If TrueSave primarily ships fragile electronic goods, that would not explain why more of those fragile goods were damaged after TrueSave began using more packing materials than before.

E. The loss of customers due to damaged shipments does nothing to explain why those shipments were damaged in the first place.

The correct answer is B.

•

An unusually severe winter occurred in Europe after the continent was blanketed by a blue haze resulting from the eruption of the Laki Volcano in the European republic of Iceland in the summer of 1984. Thus, it is evident that major eruptions cause the atmosphere to become cooler than it would be otherwise.

Which of the following statements, if true, most seriously weakens the argument above?

A. The cooling effect triggered by volcanic eruptions in 1985 was counteracted by an unusual warming of Pacific waters.

B. There is a strong statistical link between volcanic eruptions and the severity of the rainy season in India.

C. A few months after El Chichón's large eruption in April 1982, air temperatures throughout the region remained higher than expected given the long-term weather trends.

D. The climatic effects of major volcanic eruptions can temporarily mask the general warming trend resulting from

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an excess of carbon dioxide in the atmosphere.

E. Three months after an early springtime eruption in South America during the late nineteenth century, sea surface temperatures near the coast began to fall.

Argument Evaluation

Situation A volcanic eruption in Iceland was followed a few months later by an unusually cold winter in Europe, possibly due to atmospheric haze from the eruption. The author posits this cooling demonstrates that large volcanic eruptions in general cause atmospheric cooling.

Reasoning *What would weaken the argument that major eruptions result in colder weather?* The argument draws a general conclusion—major volcanic eruptions cause atmospheric cooling—from a single example: cold weather following the eruption of Laki Volcano in 1984. Thus, any examples of volcanic eruptions that do *not* show a similar effect on atmospheric temperatures would tend to weaken the argument that such atmospheric cooling is a general result of major eruptions.

A. The fact that cooling resulting from other eruptions was countered by a separate trend of oceanic warming would not weaken the argument that major volcanic eruptions in general cool the atmosphere.

B. A correlation between major eruptions and severe rainy seasons in India has no bearing on the argument that major eruptions have a cooling effect on climate.

C. **Correct.** If a different major volcanic eruption was followed by unexpectedly warm weather, rather than by cooling, that would tend to weaken the argument that major volcanic eruptions produce colder weather as a rule.

D. Even if atmospheric cooling caused by volcanoes could mask the warming caused by excessive atmospheric carbon dioxide, that has no bearing on the question of whether large eruptions in general cause cooling.

E. Oceanic cooling following an eruption has no bearing on the argument's claim regarding atmospheric cooling.

The correct answer is C.

•

Political theorist: Even with the best spies, area experts, and satellite surveillance, foreign policy assessments can still lack important information. In such circumstances intuitive judgment is vital. A national leader with such judgment can make good decisions about foreign policy even when current information is incomplete, since _____.

Which of the following, if true, most logically completes the argument?

A. the central reason for failure in foreign policy decision making is the absence of critical information

B. those leaders whose foreign policy decisions have been highly ranked have also been found to have good intuitive judgment

C. both intuitive judgment and good information are required for sound decision-making

D. good foreign policy decisions often lead to improved methods of gathering information

E. intuitive judgment can produce good decisions based on past experience, even when there are important gaps in current information

Argument Construction

Situation National leaders sometimes must make foreign policy decisions while lacking important information.

Reasoning *What would most help support the claim that a national leader with intuitive judgment can make good foreign policy decisions without complete information?* The word *since* preceding the blank indicates that the blank should be filled with a premise supporting the statement immediately before the blank. So, an observation that supports the claim that a national leader with intuitive judgment can make good foreign policy decisions without complete information would logically complete the argument.

A. This gives us no reason to suppose that intuitive judgment helps national leaders avoid such failures.

B. This does not specify who ranked the foreign policy decisions, nor how they determined the rankings, so it gives us no reason to accept those rankings. For all we know, the anonymous rankers may have used the dubious

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rankings they created as the sole evidence for their so-called findings about which leaders have good intuitive judgment.

C. This implies that intuitive judgment alone is inadequate without good information, so it undermines rather than supports the claim that national leaders can make good foreign policy decisions with intuitive judgment while lacking complete information.

D. This gives us no reason to suppose that good foreign policy decisions can be made in the first place by leaders lacking important information.

E. **Correct.** This suggests that national leaders can make good foreign policy decisions using intuitive judgment based on their past foreign policy experience, even without complete information about the current situations they're facing.

The correct answer is E.

•

Supply shortages and signs of growing demand are driving cocoa prices upward. Unusually severe weather in cocoa-producing regions—too much rain in Brazil and too little in West Africa—has limited production. Further, Europe and North America recently reported stronger demand for cocoa. In the first quarter, grinding of cocoa beans—the first stage in processing cocoa for chocolate—rose 8.1 percent in Europe and 16 percent in North America. Analysts have concluded that cocoa's price will continue to rise at least into the near future.

Which of the following would, if true, most strengthen the reasoning above?

A. Ground cocoa beans can be stored for long periods before they spoil.

B. Several European and North American manufacturers that use cocoa have recently improved their processing capacity.

C. It takes new cocoa trees five or six years before they start bearing fruit.

D. Governments in Europe and North America are likely to change current restrictions on cocoa imports.

E. Historically, cocoa production has varied widely from year to year.

Argument Evaluation

Situation There has been limited production of cocoa beans due to severe weather and also increased demand for cocoa; as a result, cocoa prices have risen.

Reasoning *What would help support the analysts' inference that cocoa prices will continue to rise at least into the near future?* If the price of cocoa is to continue to rise, then the conditions that have led to the recent increase in price must not be ameliorated. They would be ameliorated if demand for cocoa beans declined, e.g., because price increases made people less likely to want ground cocoa; they would also be ameliorated if supply increased, e.g., because many new cocoa trees were planted and very quickly started bearing fruit. If we had reason to believe that one or more of these ameliorating factors is unlikely to happen, then we have more reason to think that prices might stay high, and possibly even rise further.

A. That ground cocoa beans can be stored for long periods without spoiling does not tell us whether supply and demand conditions will stay stable, improve, or get worse.

B. The fact that these manufacturers have recently improved their processing capacity might help explain why the grinding of cocoa beans has increased recently, but it does not indicate that this increased capacity will be fully utilized. Often, if end-product demand decreases, industrial capacity will become underutilized.

C. **Correct.** If it takes new cocoa trees several years to start bearing fruit, then it is less likely that supply can quickly be increased, which in turn makes it less likely that supply can quickly meet any increased demand and thereby relieve pricing pressures.

D. These governments may change current restrictions on cocoa imports, but for all we know, they may make them more restrictive rather than less restrictive. If they made them more restrictive, demand might decrease, in which case prices might actually fall.

E. If cocoa production varies from year to year, it could be that next year cocoa production increases, in which case, as long as demand does not increase as well, prices might fall.

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case, as long as demand does not increase as well, prices might fall.

The correct answer is C.

•

During the earliest period of industrialization in Britain, steam engines were more expensive to build and operate than either windmills or water mills, the other practicable sources of power for factories. Yet despite their significant cost disadvantage, steam-powered factories were built in large numbers well before technical improvements brought their cost down. Furthermore, they were built even in regions where geographical conditions permitted the construction of wind- and water-powered factories close to major markets.

Which of the following, if true, most helps to explain the proliferation of steam-powered factories during the earliest period of industrialization in Britain?

A. In many areas of Britain, there were fewer steam-powered factories than wind- or water-powered factories in the earliest period of industrialization.

B. Unlike wind- or water-powered factories, steam-powered factories were fueled with coal, which sometimes had to be transported significant distances from the mine to the site of the factory.

C. It was both difficult and expensive to convert a factory from wind power or water power to steam power.

D. In the early period of industrialization, many goods sold in towns and cities could not be mass-produced in factories.

E. In Britain, the number of sites where a wind- or water-powered factory could be built was insufficient to provide for all of the demand for factory-produced goods at the time.

Argument Construction

Situation	Although steam engines were more expensive than windmills and water mills in early industrial Britain, many steam-powered factories were built even in regions where the construction of wind- and water-powered factories was geographically feasible.
Reasoning	*Why might steam-powered factories have proliferated despite their cost disadvantage?* Early industrialists would have needed some positive reason to choose steam over less expensive power sources for their factories. For example, steam engines might have operated faster or more effectively than windmills or water mills. Or steam engines might have received government subsidies. Or conditions restricting the number or locations of windmills and water mills might have forced industrialists to use steam power instead.

A. This suggests that the steam-powered factories did not initially proliferate as widely as they might have, but it does not explain why they proliferated to the extent that they did.

B. The inconvenience of transporting coal for steam-powered factories would have made those factories less likely to proliferate, not more likely.

C. The difficulty of converting factories to steam power would have made steam-powered factories less likely to proliferate, not more likely.

D. The technological inability to mass-produce popular products in factories would have made factories in general less likely to proliferate, including steam-powered factories.

E. **Correct.** The inadequate number of sites for wind- and water-powered factories might have encouraged early industrialists to build steam-powered factories instead, since the high demand for factory-produced goods could have made these factories profitable despite their cost disadvantage.

The correct answer is E.

•

A popular beach has long had a dolphin-feeding program in which fish are given to dolphins several times a day. Many dolphins get as much as half of their food each day there. Although dolphins that first benefit from the program as adults are healthy and long-lived, their offspring have a lower life expectancy than offspring of dolphins that feed exclusively in the wild.

Which of the following, if true, most helps to explain the lower life expectancy of offspring of dolphins feeding at the beach compared to other young dolphins?

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beach compared to other young dolphins?

A. Sharks that prey on dolphins are less common in the open seas off the beach than in many other areas of the open seas where dolphins congregate.

B. Many of the adult dolphins that feed at the beach are females that nurse their offspring there.

C. The fish given to the dolphins at the beach are the same types of fish that dolphins typically catch in the wild.

D. Many dolphins that feed at the beach with their offspring come to the beach only a few times a month.

E. Adult dolphins that feed at the beach spend much less time teaching their offspring how to catch fish in the wild than do other adult dolphins.

Argument Construction

Situation A program that feeds dolphins fish at a beach has no negative effect on adult dolphins, but the offspring of the human-fed dolphins generally have shorter lives than the offspring of dolphins that hunt their own food.

Reasoning *What factor would explain why the dolphin-feeding program negatively affects the offspring of dolphin recipients?* The dolphin-feeding program produces no problems for adults that eat fish provided by humans, but their young fare worse than the young of dolphins that catch all their own fish. Therefore, some additional complication of the program is likely to explain these negative effects.

A. Fewer sharks preying on dolphins near the beach would be expected to increase, not reduce, the life expectancy of young dolphins that frequent that area.

B. The proportion of nursing females among the fed dolphins has no bearing on why their offspring have reduced life expectancy.

C. The fact that fed dolphins and freely hunting dolphins eat the same types of fish does nothing to explain why the offspring of the first group have generally shorter lives than the second group.

D. The frequency with which dolphins take advantage of the feeding program would not explain why the offspring of fed dolphins have worse outcomes.

E. **Correct.** The passage states that the fed dolphins derive at most half their total food from the feeding program, so if fed dolphins spend less time teaching their young to hunt on their own, then those young would be at a serious disadvantage relative to the well-taught young of wild-feeding dolphins. Therefore, such an effect of the feeding program would explain the negative impact on life expectancy among the offspring.

The correct answer is E.

•

Plant scientists have used genetic engineering on seeds to produce crop plants that are highly resistant to insect damage. Unfortunately, the seeds themselves are quite expensive, and the plants require more fertilizer and water to grow well than normal ones. Accordingly, **for most farmers the savings on pesticides would not compensate for the higher seed costs and the cost of additional fertilizer.** However, since consumer demand for grains, fruits, and vegetables grown without the use of pesticides continues to rise, the use of genetically engineered seeds of this kind is likely to become widespread.

In the argument given, the two portions in **boldface** play which of the following roles?

A. The first supplies a context for the argument; the second is the argument's main conclusion.

B. The first introduces a development that the argument predicts will have a certain outcome; the second is a state of affairs that, according to the argument, contributes to bringing about that outcome.

C. The first presents a development that the argument predicts will have a certain outcome; the second acknowledges a consideration that tends to weigh against that prediction.

D. The first provides evidence to support a prediction that the argument seeks to defend; the second is that prediction.

E. The first and the second each provide evidence to support the argument's main conclusion.

Argument Construction

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Argument Construction

Situation Seeds genetically engineered by plant scientists produce crops that are highly resistant to insect damage, and such crops can be grown with less use of pesticides. The seeds would be costly to use, and the savings on pesticides would not be sufficient, in themselves, to increase most farmers' profitability. Nonetheless, consumer demand for pesticide-free food materials is increasing, so genetically engineered seeds are likely to become widely used.

Reasoning *What function is served by the statement that plant scientists have used genetic engineering on seeds to produce insect-resistant crop plants? What function is served by the statement that for most farmers the savings on pesticides would not outweigh other associated costs?* The first statement describes an innovation—genetically engineered seeds—that allows crops to be grown with little or no use of pesticides. The second statement notes that savings on pesticide use would not outweigh the higher costs of the genetically engineered seeds. The argument's main conclusion, however, is the prediction, expressed in the second clause of the final sentence of the passage, that use of such genetically engineered seeds will become widespread.

A. The second statement is not the main conclusion. Instead, it is an intermediate conclusion, which is based on the preceding statements. The main conclusion is presented in the final clause of the passage.

B. This correctly characterizes the first statement but not the second. The second statement is not meant to indicate a factor that contributes to the predicted outcome; instead, it indicates a factor that could hypothetically count against the argument's prediction.

C. **Correct.** The first **boldfaced** portion reports a development in agricultural technology. In the final sentence, the argument goes on to predict that an outcome of this development will be the widespread adoption of insect-resistant genetically engineered seeds. The second **boldfaced** portion acknowledges a financial consideration that would tend to count against that prediction.

D. The first statement does provide partial support for the prediction stated in the argument's main conclusion. The second statement does not provide any support for the prediction that the argument seeks to defend. That prediction is expressed in the final clause of the passage and is the main conclusion of the argument.

E. The second statement cannot accurately be described as giving evidence to support the prediction stated in the argument's main conclusion. Instead, it tangentially acknowledges a consideration that could plausibly be thought to count against the conclusion.

The correct answer is C.

•

Which of the following most logically completes the passage?

Leptin, a protein occurring naturally in the blood, appears to regulate how much fat the body carries by speeding up the metabolism and decreasing the appetite when the body has too much fat. Mice that do not naturally produce leptin have more fat than other mice, but they lose fat rapidly when they are given leptin injections. Unfortunately, however, leptin cannot be used as a dietary supplement to control fat, since _____.

A. the digestive system breaks down proteins before they can enter the bloodstream

B. there are pharmaceuticals already available that can contribute to weight loss by speeding up the metabolism

C. people with unusually low levels of leptin in their blood tend to have a high percentage of body fat

D. the mice that do not naturally produce leptin were from a specially bred strain of mice

E. mice whose bodies did produce leptin also lost some of their body fat when given leptin injections

Argument Construction

Situation Leptin, a protein naturally occurring in the bloodstream, speeds up metabolism to induce loss of excessive fat. Mice that lack leptin have more fat than other mice, but they lose fat when given leptin injections. However, leptin cannot be used as a dietary supplement to control fat.

Reasoning *What would explain the fact that a dietary supplement of leptin will not help to control fat?* Leptin injected into the bloodstream—but not leptin taken as a dietary supplement—helps control fat. So,

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injected into the bloodstream—but not leptin taken as a dietary supplement—helps control fat. So, leptin taken as a dietary supplement is either inactivated in the gastrointestinal system or for some other reason fails to enter the bloodstream.

A. **Correct.** The digestive system breaks down proteins and would therefore break down leptin, which is a protein. This means that leptin given as a dietary supplement would never reach the bloodstream.

B. The question concerns leptin alone, and this new information fails to explain why leptin cannot help control fat if administered as a dietary supplement.

C. It is unsurprising that this would be so, but this information does nothing to explain why leptin consumed as a supplement would fail to control fat.

D. Presumably leptin administered as a dietary supplement was first tested on mice bred to lack leptin. However, the question about leptin does not concern only mice but presumably humans and other mammals.

E. This suggests that boosting existing normal leptin levels with injections can induce further fat loss. However, this has no obvious relevance to the question raised about why dietary supplements of leptin fail to produce fat loss.

The correct answer is A.

•

Large national budget deficits do not cause large trade deficits. If they did, countries with the largest budget deficits would also have the largest trade deficits. In fact, when deficit figures are adjusted so different countries are reliably comparable to each other, there is no such correlation.

If the statements above are all true, which of the following can properly be inferred on the basis of them?

A. Countries with large national budget deficits tend to restrict foreign trade.

B. Reliable comparisons of the deficit figures of one country with those of another are impossible.

C. Reducing a country's national budget deficit will not necessarily result in a lowering of any trade deficit that country may have.

D. When countries are ordered from largest to smallest in terms of population, the smallest countries generally have the smallest budget and trade deficits.

E. Countries with the largest trade deficits never have similarly large national budget deficits.

Argument Construction

Situation Large trade deficits are not the result of large national budget deficits. When adjustments are made so that different countries can be compared to one another, no correlation between greater budget deficits and greater trade deficits appears in the data.

Reasoning *What inference would logically follow from the information?* If it is true that there is not a causal relationship between the size of a nation's budget deficit and the size of its trade deficit, then it can be inferred that reducing a budget deficit will not necessarily result in a lower trade deficit.

A. The passage implies nothing about the trade policies of countries with large budget deficits.

B. The passage states adjustments *can* be made to allow reliable comparisons between the deficits of different countries; it does not suggest reliable comparisons are impossible.

C. **Correct.** If there is no causal relationship between budget deficits and trade deficits, then one can infer that lowering the former would not necessarily have any effect on the latter.

D. The passage implies nothing about a relationship between a nation's population and its deficits.

E. The passage states there is no *general* correlation between high budget deficits and high trade deficits; it does not imply *specific* countries never have both.

The correct answer is C.

•

Archaeologists use technology to analyze ancient sites. It is likely that this technology will advance considerably in

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the near future, allowing archaeologists to gather more information than is currently possible. If they study certain sites now, they risk contaminating or compromising them for future studies. Therefore, in order to maximize the potential for gathering knowledge in the long run, a team of archaeologists plans to delay the examination of a newly excavated site.

Which of the following would be most useful to investigate for the purpose of evaluating the plan's prospects for achieving its goal?

A. Whether any of the contents of the site will significantly deteriorate before the anticipated technology is available

B. Whether there will continue to be improvements on the relevant technology

C. Whether the team can study a site other than the newly excavated site for the time being

D. Whether the site was inhabited by a very ancient culture

E. Whether the anticipated technology will damage objects under study

Evaluation of a Plan

Situation To avoid prematurely compromising a newly excavated site, an archaeological team plans to postpone examining it until more advanced technology is developed that will let them gather more information from it. Their goal is to maximize the potential for gathering knowledge.

Reasoning *What would be most helpful to investigate in order to assess how likely it is that delaying examination of the site will maximize the potential for gathering knowledge from it?* In order to maximize (or even increase) the potential for gathering knowledge from the site by delaying its examination, the risk of compromising the site by examining it now has to be greater than the risk that the site will be compromised as much or more by delaying the examination. The delay might also increase the risk that the site will never be examined at all—for example, the team might lose its funding while it delays, or changes in local political conditions might prevent the site's future examination. Investigating any of these risks could be helpful in assessing the likelihood that the team's plan will achieve its goal.

A. **Correct.** If any of the site's contents will significantly deteriorate before the technology becomes available, that could reduce the ability to gather future information from the site even more than examining and compromising the site now would.

B. The passage already tells us that it is likely the technology *will advance considerably in the near future*. Given this information, further inquiry into whether there will be any ongoing (perhaps minor) improvements is somewhat redundant and probably of minimal value with respect to evaluating the plan's likelihood of success.

C. Even if the team can study a second site in the meantime, they might maximize the overall potential for gathering knowledge by delaying the examination of either site, both sites, or neither site until more advanced technology is available.

D. The age of the culture that inhabited the site is irrelevant to assessing the risks of delaying the site's examination until more advanced technology is available.

E. Even if the anticipated technology will damage or destroy the objects under study, it might still maximize the amount of knowledge that can be gathered from those objects. Without any comparison between the damage risk that would be incurred by proceeding with the current technology and the damage risk that would be incurred by waiting, the mere fact that some damage would occur is irrelevant.

The correct answer is A.

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